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Case ID: SOC - 002

Investigating a Suspicious Recruitment Email

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Investigation Objective

Determine whether a reported recruitment email is a phishing attempt by analyzing its email headers, authentication results, message content, and technical indicators.

Investigation Scope

This investigation focused on:

- Reviewing the sender and recipient information.
- Validating email authentication (SPF, DKIM, DMARC).
- Examining the email content for social engineering techniques.
- Identifying Indicators of Compromise (IOCs).
- Determining whether the available evidence supported a phishing classification.

Tools Used: Email Header Analyzer, Manual Header Analysis



Evidence1:Email Overview

Investigation Question:

Who sent the email, who received it, and what is the purpose of the message?

Why I Investigated This:

I first reviewed the basic email information to understand the context of the reported message before beginning technical analysis. This establishes who sent the email, who received it, and what action the sender is requesting.

Evidence Collected:

Field	Value
Sender	Mantra Falcon
Recipient	xmarksthespot[.]gmail[.]com
Subject	Sr. AI Engineer opening
Date	Wed, 6 Aug 2025 17:53:06 -0400 (EDT)

Screenshot:

Figure 1 – Email overview showing the sender, recipient, subject, and date.

```
DKIM-Signature: v=1; a=rsa-sha256; c=relaxed/relaxed; d=talent[.]terrigenisis[.]com;
s=scph1117; t=1754517187; i=[@]talent[.]terrigenisis[.]com;
bh=[redacted];
h=Date:From:To:Message-ID:Subject:Content-Type:X-CSA-Complaints:
List-Unsubscribe:List-Unsubscribe-Post:From:To:Cc:Subject;
b=[redacted]
Received: from [10[.]90[.]23[.]234] ([10[.]90[.]23[.]234])
by i-04f35ffad71e9353.mta1vrest.sd.pr.d.sparkpost (ecelerity 5.1.0.74578 r(msys-ecelerity:tags/5.1.0.3)) with
REST
id 88/8A-45403-3CEC3986; Wed, 06 Aug 2025 21:53:07 +0000
Date: Wed, 6 Aug 2025 17:53:06 -0400 (EDT)
From: Mantra Falcon
Reply-To: Mantra Falcon
To: xmarksthespot[@]gmail[.]com
Message-ID: <955445473[.]62711[.]7145517168948[@]ip-10[.]47[.]164[.]231[.]ec2[.]internal>
Subject: Sr. AI Engineer opening
MIME-Version: 1.0
```

What I Found:

I reviewed the basic email information to establish the investigation context. The message presented itself as a recruitment email advertising a Senior AI Engineer position. Since recruitment emails are frequently used in phishing campaigns, I continued the investigation by examining the email headers and authentication results.

Evidence 2:Email Header Analysis

Investigation Question:

Do the email headers indicate that the sender is legitimate, or do they contain evidence of spoofing?

Why I Investigated This:

I analyzed the email headers to verify the sender's identity and determine whether the email passed industry-standard authentication checks. Email headers provide valuable information about the sender, routing path, and authentication status.

Evidence Collected:

Header	Observation
From	Mantra Falcon
Reply-To	Matches the sender
Return-Path	bounces[@]terrigenisis[.]com
DKIM	Pass
SPF	Pass
DMARC	Pass
Transport	TLS 1.2

Screenshot:

Figure 2 – Email header showing authentication results and routing information.

```
ARC-Seal: i=1; a=rsa-sha256; t=1754517188; cv=none;  
d=google[.]com; s=arc-20240605;  
b=[redacted]  
ARC-Message-Signature: i=1; a=rsa-sha256; c=relaxed/relaxed; d=google[.]com; s=arc-20240605;  
h=list-id:list-unsubscribe-post:list-unsubscribe:precedence  
:mime-version:subject:message-id:to:reply-to:from:date  
:dkim-signature;  
bh=[redacted];  
fh=[redacted];  
b=[redacted];  
dara=google[.]com  
ARC-Authentication-Results: i=1; mx[.]google[.]com;  
dkim=pass header.i=[@]talent[.]terrigenisis[.]com header.s=scph1117 header.b=[redacted];  
spf=pass (google[.]com: domain of msprvs1=203139os2ep8r=bounces-7869-  
1103[@]bounces[.]terrigenisis[.]com designates 182[.]247[.]176[.]30 as permitted sender)  
smtp.mailfrom="msprvs1=203139oS2eP8r=bounces-7869-1103[@]bounces[.]terrigenisis[.]com";  
dmarc=pass (p=REJECT sp=REJECT dis=NONE) header.from=talent[.]terrigenisis[.]com
```

What I Found:

I reviewed the email headers and confirmed that the message successfully passed SPF, DKIM, and DMARC authentication checks. I also observed that the Reply-To address matched the sender information, and I did not identify obvious indicators of email spoofing during header analysis.

Although the authentication results were valid, this alone does not guarantee that an email is safe. Attackers may also use legitimate or compromised domains, so additional analysis of the email content was required.

Evidence 3: Email Content Analysis

Investigation Question:

Does the email contain social engineering techniques or suspicious requests?

Why I Investigated This:

I examined the email body to identify common phishing characteristics such as urgency, credential requests, suspicious hyperlinks, or attempts to manipulate the recipient into taking immediate action.

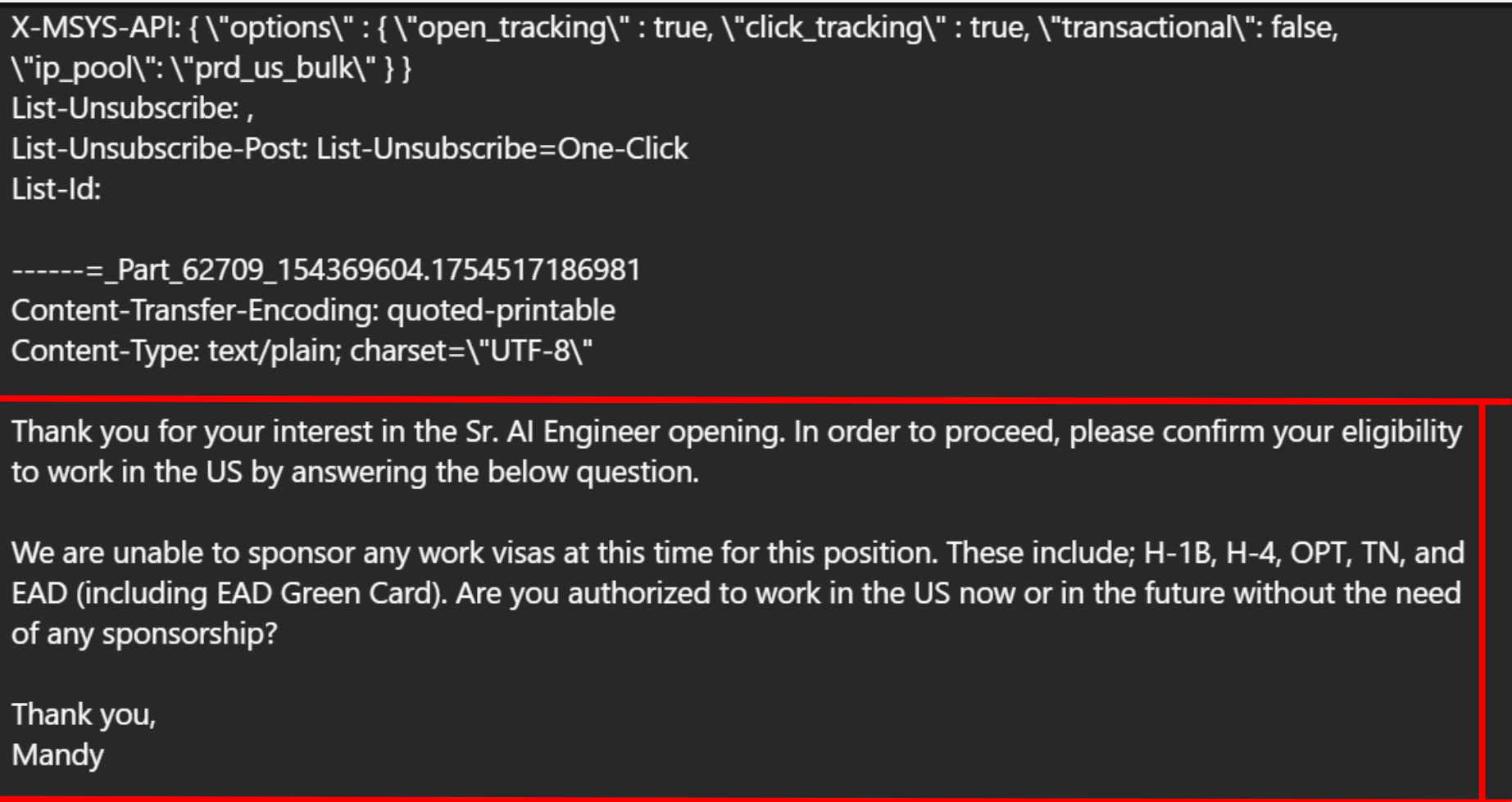
Evidence Collected:

I reviewed:

- Email body
- Requested action
- Embedded hyperlinks
- Attachments

Screenshot:

Figure 3 – Email body reviewed during the investigation.



What I Found:

The email presented itself as a recruitment message asking the recipient to confirm whether they were authorized to work in the United States without requiring visa sponsorship.

During my review, I did not observe requests for passwords, banking information, or other sensitive credentials. I also did not identify threatening language or urgency designed to pressure the recipient into taking immediate action.

Based on the available evidence, the email appeared to be an initial employment screening message. However, because recruitment emails are commonly used in phishing campaigns, I continued investigating the embedded links before reaching a conclusion.

Evidence 4: Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

Investigation Question:

What technical indicators were identified during the investigation?

Why I Investigated This:

I extracted technical indicators that could support future investigations, threat hunting activities, or detection rules within a Security Operations Center.

Evidence Collected:

Header	Observation
Sender Name	Mantra Falcon
Sender Domain	talent[.]terrigenisis[.]com
Return-Path Domain	bounces[.]terrigenisis[.]com
Tracking URL	hxxps://tracking[.]terrigenisis[.]com/f/[redacted]
Subject	Sr. AI Engineer opening
Authentication	SPF Pass, DKIM Pass, DMARC Pass

Screenshot:

Figure 4 – Email footer showing the embedded tracking URL.

-----=_Part_62709_154369604.1754517186981

Content-Transfer-Encoding: quoted-printable

Content-Type: text/plain; charset=\"UTF-8\"

Thank you for your interest in the Sr. AI Engineer opening. In order to proceed, please confirm your eligibility to work in the US by answering the below question.

We are unable to sponsor any work visas at this time for this position. These include; H-1B, H-4, OPT, TN, and EAD (including EAD Green Card). Are you authorized to work in the US now or in the future without the need of any sponsorship?

Thank you,
Mandy

This message was sent to abulkhairsiddiqui53[.]gmail[.]com. If you don't want to receive these emails from this company in the future, please go to:

hxxps://tracking[.]terrigenisis[.]com/f/[redacted]

/n (c) Maha Health, LLC, Virginia, 22102, USA/n

-----=_Part_62709_154369604.1754517186981

What I Found:

I identified an embedded tracking URL hosted on the terrigenisis.com domain. Tracking links are commonly used by legitimate recruitment and marketing platforms to measure email engagement. Based on the available evidence, I did not identify malicious attachments, credential harvesting requests, or executable files within the email.

I documented the sender domains and tracking URL as Indicators of Compromise (IOCs) for future validation or threat hunting if additional suspicious activity were reported.

Investigation Summary:

I investigated a reported recruitment email by reviewing its metadata, email headers, authentication results, message content, and technical indicators.

The email successfully passed SPF, DKIM, and DMARC authentication checks, reducing the likelihood of sender spoofing. The email requested confirmation of work authorization and did not ask for passwords, financial information, or other sensitive credentials.

I also identified an embedded tracking URL hosted on the sender's domain. While tracking links should always be reviewed carefully, the available evidence did not indicate malicious activity.

Based on the evidence collected during this investigation, I could not confirm that the email was a phishing attempt. Additional verification of the sender organization and embedded tracking URL would be recommended before interacting with the email.

Recommendations:

- Verify the sender organization before responding to recruitment emails.
- Validate embedded domains using approved threat intelligence sources.
- Avoid clicking hyperlinks until the sender's legitimacy has been confirmed.
- Continue monitoring for follow-up emails requesting credentials, payments, or file downloads.

Lessons Learned:

- I learned how to analyze email headers to verify sender authenticity using SPF, DKIM, and DMARC.
- I practiced reviewing email content for common social engineering techniques without making assumptions.
- I documented technical indicators that could support future investigations and threat hunting.
- I reinforced the importance of making conclusions based on observable evidence rather than assumptions.

Skills Demonstrated:

- Email Triage
- Email Header Analysis
- SPF, DKIM, and DMARC Validation
- Social Engineering Assessment
- Indicator of Compromise (IOC) Identification
- Evidence-Based Reporting
- Security Documentation